to communist countries. In 1985, Washington allowed General Electric to sell gas turbine engines for Chinese destroyers and helped with the modernization of munitions and artillery as well as advanced avionics for China's F-8 aircraft. In 1986, the first US ships with nuclear weapons capabilities visited Chinese ports. It was not all strategic interaction. People-to-people links also increased rapidly: in 1982, 100,000 Americans visited China, and 10,000 Chinese students were in the US. By 1986, American visitors to China had increased threefold, and by 1987 Chinese students in the US had increased by a factor of ten.[27]

Détentes

Despite India's misgiving about the Soviets in Afghanistan, India too deepened its partnership. It opposed the Soviet presence but refused to criticize Moscow too publicly. More importantly, it continued to buy Soviet weaponry, often on concessional terms. Between 1980 and 1985, India may have bought Soviet arms worth up to $13 billion.[28] By late 1981, though, Delhi was looking to mend relations with Washington. The geopolitical environment around India in South Asia had worsened due to the Soviet intervention in Afghanistan: as a front-line state against the Soviets, Pakistan was receiving massive economic and military assistance; the Pakistani nuclear programme was advancing thanks to the US and China; and India confronted a China–Pakistan–US coalition. At the same time, the Indian economy was in the doldrums, and it needed technology and investment from the West.

The key to India's geopolitical and economic challenges was improving ties with the US. The US responded positively to India's outreach. Its principal motive was to draw India away from the Soviets, and in 1981 Reagan met Mrs Gandhi at Cancun. The following year Mrs Gandhi made her first visit to America in a decade. Her assassination in 1984 brought Rajiv Gandhi to power, and his 1985 and 1987 visits to Washington attempted to build on his mother's opening to the US. However, when his